

It's Not Cricket

The three former cricketers in the IPL's governing council made big bucks by playing several roles at the same time

After Lalit Modi and BCCI secretary N. Srinivasan, the most famous names in the IPL's charmed 'conflict of interest' circle belong to the IPL governing council's "ex-cricketers of repute".

In responding to the issue, former India captain Mansur Ali Khan Pataudi said that his son Saif Ali Khan had told him he was interested in a team. But Pataudi had not told about his son's plans for a formal bid which eventually failed to win one of the two new 2010 franchises.

Apart from Pataudi, Sunil Gavaskar and Ravi Shastri are also part of the first IPL governing council and get what is estimated to be a paycheque of Rs 1.5 crore each per year. Shastri told INDIA TODAY, "Yes, the governing council job is a paid post," but when asked about the pay, he laughed, "Never ask a

ent entity with a five-year term. Clause 32 (vii) states that adjudication of a case of inquiry around indiscipline or misconduct "should be completed within six months".

Within six months will mean the BCCI's annual September lovefest, its general election, will have come and gone and it should be an extremely busy month with the Champions T20 League to be held in South Africa (September 12-26) and the governing council's strongest sporting suit, the three former cricketers entering into discussions with franchises and setting up base prices for players to be auctioned. In another time, the man awaiting September could be the BCCI's



(FROM LEFT TO RIGHT) IPL GOVERNING COUNCIL MEMBERS SUNIL GAVASKAR, M.A.K. PATAUDI, RAVI SHASTRI, AND INTERIM CHAIRMAN CHIRAYU AMIN

man his salary." Unlike Pataudi, Shastri and Gavaskar are not merely the League's legislators, but vital cogs of its endorsement machinery. They are now part of the BCCI's commentary team and are included in all panels in every India series, the deal worth \$1million (Rs 4.5 crore) a year. The BCCI then also works their terms with companies owning rights to India games, like Nimbus for example, who owns home games rights. A Nimbus production executive said, "An imposing fee of \$10,000 per day for each was suggested to us by Modi, which we refused. It was 10 times the normal rate." The Nimbus contract now earns them \$1,000-\$1,200 each per commentary day.

During governing council meetings Shastri said he would "step in for the cricketing stuff whenever it came up," adding, "when something of this magnitude takes off, things are bound to happen. But from now on transparency will be total." Pity it took sky-high salaries and 40 meetings for that to happen.

own president elect N. Srinivasan, as it is the South Zone's turn to find a successor for Manohar. What he least needs is legal tangles around his own credibility for the job. Amin has already promised, "a bigger, better and more transparent IPL for Season 4". It might just be an empty dream as the Modi-BCCI confrontation is now a very sticky wicket for both parties.

An international cricket administrator once said Modi reminded him of George Bush: "Either you are for him or you are against him". At the moment, the once-commissar of international cricket knows exactly who is not on his side. And they know it too. ■